

Are some topics too sensitive to be discussed? Balancing social and individual needs

- The ethical matters worth discussing are sensitive matters – genuine moral dilemmas about which we care and disagree.
- It's important to balance the need for discussion and accommodating the needs of those who may be triggered by certain topics (unpleasant political ideas, violence, etc)
- Banning topics is not an option that we should ever contemplate. Silence suits criminals, offenders, and prevents change. The more tension/disagreement there is, the more civilized dialogue is essential
- A common approach to discussing these matters is to keep it casual and joke about it, not because the issues are casual but because they are serious
- For instance, Michael Sandel (Harvard lectures) talks somewhat jokingly about thought experiments involving murder and cannibalism, and in ethics many examples include choosing who must die

To protect you

- 1. This warning of potentially triggering topics is issued at the start of each term - Readings and discussions may include emotionally challenging topics
- 2. You can skip specific discussions in class if you find the topic triggering and we'll do our best to accommodate this (not deduct participation marks, etc)
- 3. I provide information about resources that could help deal with the traumatic events and topics

Resources

- Graphic examples are avoided when possible/appropriate.
If you still feel you were hurt:
 - a. Counselling is available at BCIT
 - b. Student judicial affairs – available to the student when there is a complaint process with informal complaints (goes up to the level of the Associate Dean) and formal complaints (goes up to the level of the Dean)
 - c. For more serious issues, Respect, Diversity and Inclusion have a procedure for complaints regarding harassment and discrimination
 - d. For very serious cases, a complaint to the BC Human Rights Tribunal can be made